Chayai Sara 5786

חיי שרה. The pasuk says that יצחק was coming towards רבקה. Why was he coming towards רבקה? Where was he going? The מדרש tells us that he was going out to daven מנחה.

The sefer אחת שאלתי - a sefer of R' Yitzchok Zilberstein's torah wisdom written by R' Erez Chazani - discusses the importance of how we should look upon our efforts at going to daven. The sefer quotes a Rabbi Markowitz, the rav of a shul called קהילת אמונים. Part of his job is to make sure that there's a מנין every day, שחרית, מנחה, מעריב. Rabbi Markowitz relates:

"One of my מתפללים, we will call him Mr. Feinstein, came regularly every day for davening, but he never came on time, he always came exactly ten minutes late. It seemed a pity that he made the effort to come to shul each morning, but was never able to daven properly as he was always late and had to rush to catch up. One time I said to him, 'Mr. Feinstein, it's so great you come to shul every morning. If you're coming anyway, why don't you come on time?' He wasn't bothered by that. 'What's the big deal of ten minutes here or there?' he asked. 'The main thing is that I made it to davening, whether it's sooner or later.'

"Over the years, I made a comment from time to time, but it did not do any good. One day, at exactly seven o'clock on the dot, walks in Mr. Feinstein, on time for the מנין for the first time that I could remember. After davening, I went over to him and I asked him to what we could attribute the honor of having him there for the beginning of davening.

"הקדוש ברוך הוא sent me a message that was crystal clear", he said with a haggard look on his face. "It's not worth coming late to davening. Let me tell you what happened. My main source of livelihood is a factory I own not far from here. A fire broke out in my factory yesterday. I called the fire department and they assured me that they would be there immediately. Minute after minute passed. I was going into hysterics as the fire spread from room to room, destroying all my expensive machinery and all my merchandise. There was no sign of a fire truck. Finally, the fire truck rolled up, but by then it was too late. The entire factory was gone. "What took you so long?" I cried. "If you had been here ten minutes earlier, you could have saved my whole factory." "What's the big deal of ten minutes here or there", the fireman asked. "The main thing is that we made it sooner or later."

"When I heard these words, my blood turned cold. That was exactly what I always had said as an excuse for coming late to davening. Hashem showed me how much damage could be caused in just ten minutes. I now understand how much good could be done in just ten minutes by coming on time to davening."

To have respect and come on time to any meeting is very וויכטיגע and a very big מעלה, it's a מידה טובה. To come to shul on time is showing respect to the shul, to הקדוש ברוך הוא, and to how important we consider davening. I always look with awe and pride at the first ten מתפללים who come to shul, and they always come on a regular basis. I give them credit because they've gotten themselves trained to do that. Anyone can train themselves to do that, and take my word for it, it's worth it.

https://youtu.be/pvf9qYB1fOo